



THE ANDEAN CARAVAN • DAYS 40-57

03

The Mirror

Silver cities, wet-season salt, high lagoons and the Atacama

A proposal you can picture yourself inside

A caravan is not a race down a route. It is a moving circle — travellers, hosts, vehicles and local knowledge — progressing slowly enough for each place to change the terms.

Section 03 is the third of four sections that tile one continuous 71-day passage from Lima to the end of the Carretera Austral. It begins at the Sucre gate and closes at the Santiago gate. This is the expedition section: the Salar, the Lagunas and three refuge nights above 4,100 m.

01 23 DAYS	02 16 DAYS	03 18 DAYS	04 14 DAYS	
LIMA	PUNO	SUCRE	SANTIAGO	BALMACEDA

YOUR GATES

Join at Sucre, leave at Santiago. A traveller who wants Titicaca, La Paz and Sucre without the Salar crossing should end at Sucre instead.

IMPORTANT

This is a route proposal, not yet a confirmed departure.

It communicates the intended route, pace and level of effort. Exact dates, named properties, suppliers, tickets, departure times, prices and meal inclusions become final only after the 2028 operating plan is secured. Weather, permits, border authorities and vessel operators can change the order or content of a day; this guide names those dependencies wherever they affect your choice.

Effort is more than walking distance

Every day separates physical effort from the operating environment. A short day can still be demanding if it sleeps high, begins early, changes hotels or removes access to easy recovery.

PHYSICAL EFFORT

■ LIGHT

Arrival, recovery, buffer or compact programme.
The point is to create room around the harder days.

■ STEADY

A normal travelling day: walking, road movement, a visit or a hotel change without concentrated load.

■ DEMANDING

Long movement, significant altitude, rough ground, early start, complex boarding or several load signals together.

OPERATING ENVIRONMENT

CONNECTED

Reliable services and straightforward access to support.

LIMITED SERVICES

Fewer choices and slower access to support; planning matters.

REMOTE

Simple infrastructure, long transfer routes and limited communications or facilities.

FREE TIME

When the guide says free time, it means genuinely uncommitted time. It is not a space waiting to be filled later by a compulsory tour.

The Mirror

The Caravan begins gently in Sucre, climbs through Potosí and Uyuni, then commits to its most remote passage: the Salar, the Lagunas, three refuge nights and the high border into Chile before recovering in the Atacama and flying to Santiago.

HIGHEST GROUND

Approx. 4,900–4,980 m in the Lagunas

MOVEMENT

Road, 4×4 convoy, foot and vehicle border, scheduled flight

HIGHEST SLEEP

Approx. 4,500–4,600 m at Refuge 2

DECLARED LOAD

Five demanding days and three refuge nights

THE STAGES

Silver and Bone	Days 40–46
The Salar and the Lagunas	Days 47–53
Red Earth, Open Sky	Days 54–57

DECLARED LOAD EXCEPTION

Days 49–53 are five consecutive demanding days, including three refuge nights and the highest ground of the Caravan. Days 48 and 54 are protected shoulders; no additional programme is placed there.

40 Sucre at arrival pace

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Sucre	Sucre	Adapted city walk	Light · Connected

A gentle orientation follows the historic core without attempting to complete it. Sucre's lower altitude is allowed to register after La Paz, before the later climb to Potosí.

FREE TIME *A substantial afternoon and evening.*

LAUNDRY	A laundry opportunity is planned here; it is expected to be the last reliable one before the Salar.
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41 Cal Orck'o

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Sucre to Cal Orck'o to Sucre	Sucre	Short road transfer and guided viewing	Steady · Connected

The morning follows the official guided footprint-viewing window available on the operating day. The vertical trackway is approached through its actual access system, not described as a free-roaming site.

FREE TIME *From early afternoon.*

42 Maragua country

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Sucre to Maragua area to Sucre	Sucre	Full-day road excursion	■ Steady · Limited services

A community and textile visit is built with the people hosting it. Walking remains short and optional. If rain makes the final approach unsuitable, the programme moves to an agreed Sucre or near-Sucre setting rather than forcing the road.

FREE TIME *Only after return to Sucre.*

43 Climb to Potosí

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Sucre to Potosí	Potosí	Approx. 3.5 to 4.5 hours road	■ Demanding · Limited services

The road gains more than 1,200 m. The arrival afternoon is kept light and close to the hotel. There is no mine visit, hill climb or full colonial circuit after the transfer.

FREE TIME *After check-in, with no scheduled exertion.*

44 Money, silver and Cerro Rico

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Potosí	Potosí	City vehicle and 2 to 4 km adjustable walk	■ Steady · Connected

Casa Nacional de Moneda anchors the day. The colonial core follows at a measured pace. Cerro Rico is read from an exterior viewpoint or interpretive setting, connecting silver, labour and the city without selling a visit to a working underground mine as entertainment.

FREE TIME *A quiet late afternoon at the same hotel.*

45 Potosí to Uyuni

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Potosí to Uyuni	Uyuni	Approx. 3.5 to 4.5 hours road	■ Steady · Limited services

The road crosses the highland to Uyuni. The Train Cemetery is visited on arrival only if daylight and the road permit. It does not justify racing the final hour.

FREE TIME *After arrival, subject to daylight.*

46 Colchani and the crossing brief

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Uyuni to Colchani to Uyuni	Uyuni	Short local road transfer	Light · Connected

Salt-making and the market at Colchani occupy a contained morning. The afternoon is held for rest, soft-bag preparation and the 4×4 safety briefing. The Salar is not previewed as a hurried add-on.

FREE TIME *Most of the afternoon around the required briefing.*

CROSSING BRIEFING	The Days 49–53 load is restated here in full, in person: five consecutive Demanding days, three refuge nights between approximately 4,100 and 4,600 m, shared bathrooms, limited heating, and a pre-dawn border day. A traveller may withdraw from the crossing at this point under the agreed terms.
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47 Approach the north shore

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Uyuni to Tunupa north shore and Coquesa	Coquesa or Tahua	Approx. 5 to 7 hours by 4×4	Steady · Remote

The convoy passes Colchani without repeating the previous day's visit, then approaches the Salar's north shore and Tunupa. Wet-season water decides whether the line uses salt, edge tracks or a combination.

FREE TIME *Only after the remote lodge or guesthouse is reached.*

48 Tunupa and the first Salar day

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Tunupa and the northern Salar	Same north-shore base	4×4 and optional 2 to 4 km walk	■ Steady · Remote

The day combines lower-slope Tunupa and Coquesa with the first full Salar allocation. Walking remains on the lower mountain and is optional. No summit attempt belongs in this route.

FREE TIME *A slow period at the same base when conditions allow.*

PROTECTED DAY	This day sits immediately before the Declared Load Exception. It stays at a single base and is not extended, however good the conditions look.
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49 A second day on the salt

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
North shore towards San Juan or Colcha K	San Juan or Colcha K area	Approx. 6 to 9 hours by 4×4	■ Demanding · Remote

A second full day is allotted to the Salar landscape as the convoy moves south. A straight flooded-salt crossing is used only where depth and crust permit. Otherwise the day follows perimeter tracks and salt access selected by the operator.

FREE TIME *None is promised before the new base.*

CHANGING SALT	Two days are allotted to the Salar. Under changing water that is the honest description; two days driving across the flooded Salar is not.
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50 Into the Lagunas

ROUTE

San Juan or Colcha K to
Cañapa and Hedionda

SLEEP

Refuge 1

MOVEMENT

Approx. 6 to 8 hours by 4×4

RHYTHM

■ Demanding · Remote

The first Lagunas day moves through a series of short landscape stops rather than one long walk. The refuge is simple and likely near 4,100 m. Warmth, water and shared-bathroom realities are disclosed before an enquiry.

FREE TIME *Only after arrival, with daylight and temperature governing what is sensible.*

51 Siloli and the stone tree

ROUTE

High lagoons to Siloli and
Árbol de Piedra

SLEEP

Refuge 2

MOVEMENT

Approx. 5 to 7 hours by 4×4

RHYTHM

■ Demanding · Remote

The convoy moves higher through the lagoons and Siloli. Stops are short, exposed and wind-dependent. The second refuge may sit around 4,500 to 4,600 m, which makes the night itself the principal demand of the day.

FREE TIME *A quiet arrival period. No optional hike is added at this sleeping altitude.*

**ALTITUDE AND
COLD**

Final departure documents will state the expected night temperature, heating hours, bedding, toilet type and emergency communications for the selected refuge.

52 Laguna Colorada

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Siloli or Ojo de Perdiz to Laguna Colorada	Refuge 3	Approx. 4 to 6 hours by 4x4	■ Demanding · Remote

A shorter driving day allows the landscape and the body more room. Laguna Colorada and the surrounding reserve are visited through brief stops. The third refuge is expected around 4,300 m, subject to the final operating line.

FREE TIME *A protected late afternoon at the refuge.*

WHY THIS DAY IS DEMANDING	The drive is the shortest of the crossing, but this is the third consecutive night at altitude in a refuge without normal recovery conditions. The cumulative sleep debt is the principal load.
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53 Geysers, border and descent

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Sol de Mañana to Hito Cajón to San Pedro de Atacama	San Pedro de Atacama	Approx. 8 to 11 hours, 4x4 and road vehicle	■ Demanding · Remote

A pre-dawn departure reaches Sol de Mañana, then Polques, the Dalí landscape and Laguna Verde before Hito Cajón. At the border the group changes from the Bolivian convoy to a Chilean road vehicle. A short border walk may be required. The road then descends roughly 2,500 m to San Pedro de Atacama.

FREE TIME *Only after border completion and arrival.*

BORDER	Reconfirm 2028 border hours and Chile's entry declarations. Travellers declare relevant food, herb, wood, animal and plant products; Chile's SAG decides what is admissible.
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54 Recovery, then Valle de la Luna

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
San Pedro de Atacama and Valle de la Luna	San Pedro de Atacama	Short road circuit	Light · Connected

The morning belongs to sleep, laundry and individual time after the Hito Cajón crossing. A timed late-afternoon visit to Valle de la Luna follows only after the group has recovered. The route uses the latest suitable entry slot available in 2028; it does not promise sunset.

FREE TIME *The entire morning and early afternoon.*

PROTECTED DAY	This day closes the Declared Load Exception. The morning is not available for any fixed content, optional excursion or early departure.
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LAUNDRY	A laundry opportunity is planned here; it is expected to be the first since Sucre.
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55 Salt, red stone and one high-country line

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Salar de Atacama plus a planned high-country line	San Pedro de Atacama	Long road circuit; final elapsed time to contract	Demanding · Limited services

The stage's one demanding high-country day. The planned route links the Salar de Atacama with a coherent high-country sequence selected against timed access and road conditions. It does not promise Toconao, Piedras Rojas, Miscanti and Miñiques all inside one ten-to-twelve-hour checklist day.

FREE TIME *None is promised before return to San Pedro de Atacama.*

56 Choose the desert's rhythm

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
San Pedro de Atacama; optional El Tatio	San Pedro de Atacama	None required; optional pre-dawn road circuit	■ Light · Connected

The core day is light. A traveller may keep the morning free or use a lower-altitude local programme. El Tatio is a pre-booked opt-in choice for travellers who want the pre-dawn high-country circuit and are ready for the cold, early start and altitude. Declining it does not mean waiting at the hotel for the "real" day to return.

FREE TIME *Substantial for the core programme.*

NIGHT SKY	A small astronomy evening may be scheduled on Day 54 or Day 56 only when sky, moon, operator capacity and weather make it worthwhile. It is never guaranteed, and it is not stacked after El Tatio for the same traveller.
PURITAMA	Outside the core programme. If later offered, it sits only as an individual choice on Day 56 and cannot be combined with El Tatio or the astronomy evening for the same traveller.

57 Calama, the flight south, and the Santiago gate

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
San Pedro de Atacama to Calama to Santiago	Santiago	Approx. 1.5 hours road plus scheduled flight	■ Steady · Connected

The Caravan drives to Calama and takes a scheduled flight to Santiago. The road and airport buffer are built around the actual 2028 departure. For travellers ending here, this is the last day of the section. For travellers continuing, the Santiago night is the gate: the close of Section 03 and the protected staging night before Patagonia.

FREE TIME *Only after arrival and check-in in Santiago.*

Where this section asks more of you

Five consecutive Demanding days under a Declared Load Exception, with three refuge nights at approximately 4,100 to 4,600 m, shared bathrooms and limited heating.

The route reaches approximately 4,900 m and may approach 4,980 m at Sol de Mañana.

Potosí is reached at 4,090 m after a sleeping-altitude gain of more than 1,200 m from Sucre.

Rough track, cold, wind and repeated vehicle entry require a specific mobility and seating assessment.

Day 53 combines a pre-dawn start, the highest point, border formalities and a long descent.

The section is a long way from a hospital for four of its days.

Maragua uses a road that can be affected by rain; an equally considered Sucre alternative is required.

A CLEAR THRESHOLD

This is the expedition section. A traveller who wants Titicaca, La Paz and Sucre without the Salar crossing can end at Sucre. A traveller joining The Mirror chooses the altitude, refuge conditions and consecutive load described here.

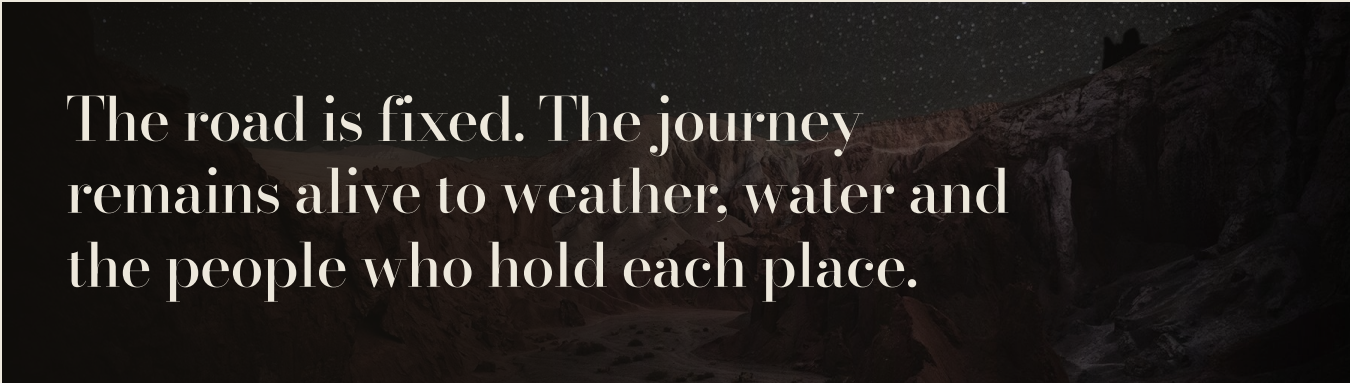
SLEEP PATTERN

Sucre three nights, Potosí two, Uyuni two. Two nights on the Salar's north shore, one at San Juan or Colcha K, three refuges. San Pedro de Atacama four consecutive nights with no repacking, from the Day 53 arrival through Day 56. The Santiago gate night closes the section.

From route proposal to your departure

This guide is the clearest picture of the intended journey through The Mirror. Before this section is offered as a secured departure, Sawayatra will reconcile the calendar, contract the route-critical trains, flights, ferries, refuges and local encounters, inspect access and accommodation, and publish the exact inclusion and cancellation terms.

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| 01 | Choose the passage | One section, consecutive sections, The Stone Road, or the full 71 days. |
| 02 | Discuss readiness | Altitude, walking, access, room basis, luggage and the demands that matter to you. |
| 03 | Receive the secured detail | Dates, price, properties, flights, inclusions, medical and insurance requirements, and the final day plan. |
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The road is fixed. The journey remains alive to weather, water and the people who hold each place.